



Children in Cumaná, Venezuela, with containers after filling them at a stream. Access to drinking water is severely limited in the city. ADRIANA LOUREIRO FERNANDEZ FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Once a Jewel of Venezuelan Industry, Now a Broken-Down Shell

By **SIMON ROMERO**

CUMANÁ, Venezuela — Drinking water in Cumaná is running extremely low. Daily blackouts plague the city. Wind howls through the looted remains of its once illustrious university. Scavengers sift through garbage dumps for scraps of food.

Much of Cumaná, a city in eastern Venezuela once a crown jewel of the country's industrial base, has the air of a battle-scarred war zone.

This coastal city is a starkly different world from Caracas, the capital, which is on the cusp of an upswing that is largely insulated from the decay across much of Venezuela.

Since U.S. forces ousted and captured President Nicolás Maduro in January, oilmen and crypto tycoons have been rushing to Caracas to explore deals.

Cumaná tells a very different story — that of the gutted economy in the rest of the country that might take generations to rebuild.

Far From Caracas's Oil Riches, Combing a Dump for Food

In May, I drove across eastern Venezuela, a dawn-to-dusk trip through more than 20 military and police checkpoints, to see living conditions outside the capital firsthand.

"You know those missile strikes

in Ukraine they're always talking about?" said José Luis Sánchez, 56, the president of Cumaná's Association of Economists, a business group. With a hint of gallows humor, he added, "Sometimes we say our city looks like Kyiv."

It was not bombing that laid waste to much of Cumaná. Instead, one-party rule, disastrous economic management and ideological vengeance campaigns are to blame, say those now openly expressing dissent in the city of

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Study Suggests Path to Prevent Lung Cancer

By **NINA AGRAWAL**

Scientists have made a discovery that may help prevent some people from developing lung cancer, which kills more people worldwide than any other cancer.

A team of more than 80 researchers working across four continents have identified a set of proteins in the blood that accurately predict lung cancers more than five years before diagnosis. The scientists also found early evidence that an existing anti-inflammatory drug could significantly reduce lung cancer risk in people with elevated concentrations of these proteins, which they linked to inflammation.

More research is needed before a test based on these proteins could be ready for use in patients. And scientists would still need to run a randomized trial to determine whether the drug prevents lung cancers. Still, outside experts said the findings, which were published on Thursday in the journal Cell, offer a promising starting point toward a long-held public health goal.

"Preventing lung cancer has been a missing holy grail for a very, very long time," said Dr. Douglas Arenberg, a professor of medicine at the University of Michigan who was not involved in the study. The authors may have identified a biological marker that "not only predicts risk but also predicts the probability of benefit

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Victor Wembanyama shook hands with all the Salesian Sisters before Game 1 of the N.B.A. finals. ERIC GAY/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Spike Who? San Antonio Has Its Own Faithful.

By **MIRIN FADER**
The Athletic

The Sisters stood inside the tunnel, waiting for the San Antonio Spurs players to emerge from the locker room. They looked up in awe as the 7-foot-4 Spurs superstar Victor Wembanyama began to walk toward them.

It was a crucial playoff game last week against the Oklahoma City Thunder, and yet Wembanyama didn't rush out to go

Nuns Bring Basketball to Their Ministry

warm up. He walked slowly toward the women, the Salesian Sisters of St. John Bosco, West Province, known formally as the Institute of the Daughters of Mary Help of Christians.

Wembanyama didn't give a quick wave or nod, or shout a kind

word or two as he passed through the tunnel. Instead, he took his time to shake hands with all nine Sisters, pausing and cupping his large hands over theirs, a beat longer than any of them expected.

"In a way, he was saying, 'Thank you,'" Sister Bernadette

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THE NOVA KNICKS A brotherhood that was forged in college is paying off at the pro level. PAGE B6

G.O.P. Lawmakers Test Trump's Grip on Party

Push Back on War and \$1.8 Billion Fund

By **KATIE ROGERS**

WASHINGTON — On a tour through Asia last fall, President Trump took a moment on the world stage to celebrate a legislative victory at home: After months of iron-fisted pressure, he had compelled Republicans to pass legislation that cut taxes and slashed into the country's social safety net.

"I said, 'Put it all into one bill, and if we get it done, we're done for four years,'" Mr. Trump said during an October speech in Tokyo. "We don't need anything more from Congress in terms of that."

Ever since, Mr. Trump has been intent on testing that theory, daring lawmakers to defy him and doing his best to drive them from office if they do. But after a retributive romp through primary season, Mr. Trump's style of governing — unilateral, and often impatient — has collided with restive Republicans who seem to be exacting some political vengeance of their own.

On Wednesday, four House Republicans sided with Democrats to demand Mr. Trump withdraw U.S. forces from the conflict with Iran or win approval from Congress, rebuking a president who has repeatedly said he does not need congressional authorization to continue the conflict.

That came on the heels of another high-profile setback: a Republican revolt against a \$1.8 billion fund to reward Trump supporters who claim political persecution by Democrats. Many Republican senators had indicated that they would not move forward with plans to pay for Mr. Trump's immigration agenda unless the move was axed. This week, Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general, said that the administration would abandon the effort.

(But on Wednesday, just as the Senate moved to debate an immigration bill that they had held up because of the fund, Mr. Trump told reporters in the Oval Office

that he wasn't quite sure if the fund was dead or on hold.

"I love it," he told a reporter who asked about the pot of money, effectively jamming his foot in the way of a door lawmakers had hoped to close. "I think it's so important.")

On other matters of national security, several Republicans pushed back on Mr. Trump's decision to appoint Bill Pulte to serve as the acting director of national intelligence. In his role as director of the Federal Housing Finance Agency, Mr. Pulte publicized the personal mortgage information of several prominent Trump critics and pushed for federal investigations into them.

Senator Thom Tillis of North Carolina said in a CNBC inter-



SALWAN GEORGES FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump's unilateral approach has raised hackles.

view on Wednesday that he did not believe Mr. Pulte "has a prayer" of being confirmed by the Senate. (Mr. Tillis announced that he would not run for re-election last year, after coming under threat from Mr. Trump for opposing the sweeping tax bill the president crowed about in Japan.)

He said that Mr. Trump's decision to appoint Mr. Pulte had jeopardized congressional efforts

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Bolton to Plead To Mishandling Classified Files

By **DEVLIN BARRETT** and **MICHAEL S. SCHMIDT**

WASHINGTON — John R. Bolton, a national security adviser to President Trump in his first term, has reached a tentative deal with prosecutors to plead guilty to mishandling classified information when he compiled notes for a book that was harshly critical of the president, according to two people familiar with the matter.

A notice in Maryland federal court, where Mr. Bolton was indicted last year, indicates he is now scheduled for a re-arraignment — a hearing that can signal a planned guilty plea. The hearing is set for June 26.

Under the terms of the plea deal, which still requires approval from a judge, Mr. Bolton plans to plead guilty to a single count of illegal retention of classified information and pay a fine, facing anywhere from no prison time to five years of incarceration when he is sentenced, according to the people familiar with the negotiations, who spoke on condition of ano-

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Behind Scenes, SpaceX's No. 2 Is Foil to Musk

By **RYAN MAC**

LOS ANGELES — Elon Musk, the chief executive of SpaceX, has dined with President Trump at the White House, lost a flashy trial where he testified against his rival Sam Altman and accompanied Mr. Trump to China for a major diplomatic summit.

Gwynne Shotwell, SpaceX's president and chief operating officer, has had a different itinerary over the last six months. She spoke at a telecom trade show in Barcelona, Spain, to boost SpaceX's satellite internet service, Starlink; mingled with politicians in India, a potentially large market for the company; and appeared with tech executives at the White House to pledge that their data centers would not increase energy prices for Americans.

For 24 years, Ms. Shotwell has played the adult-in-the-room foil to Mr. Musk at SpaceX. While he was advising Mr. Trump and running his other companies, such as the electric carmaker Tesla, she was focused on developing

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Government Lawyers Quit The departure of more than 10,000 federal lawyers has left some agencies without enough staff, and has boosted the ranks of advocacy groups. PAGE A10	Drones Blindside Israel Hezbollah's fiber-optic drone onslaught has exposed cracks in Israeli defenses, forcing political and military leaders to scramble for solutions. PAGE A8	Inspired by SpaceX's I.P.O. Few are as delighted by the pending market debut as the vibrant community of space enthusiasts who want to push discovery of the final frontier. PAGE B1	Alice's Return to New York A mural depicting a New York-centric view of Lewis Carroll's tale fell into disrepair. Now it's restored, and residents can soon view it again. PAGE C1	Jen Easterly PAGE A18

A testament to how theater can change the world.

Joe Mantello's beautiful and haunting production of 'Death of a Salesman' boasts a dream of a domestic quartet in Nathan Lane, Laurie Metcalf, Christopher Abbott, and Ben Ahlers.

— Ben Brantley

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Critic's Pick